

The Alhambra

A spectacular citadel and palace rising above the city of Granada, the finest surviving example of Moorish architecture in Spain



Perched strategically on a hill, with a commanding view of the surrounding region, the Alhambra was originally built in the 9th century as a military stronghold. “Alhambra” means “the red,” referring to its distinctive brickwork, but it became far more than just a fortress. Under the Nasrids (1232–1492), the last Muslim dynasty to rule over Iberia, parts of it were transformed into a sumptuous palace.

The main improvements were carried out in the 14th century by Yusuf I and Muhammad V. The materials used for decoration were modest enough—mostly ceramic tiles, stucco, and timber—but the quality of the craftsmanship was outstanding. Every available surface was festooned with vegetal and geometric patterns or calligraphic inscriptions. More impressive still was the exquisite honeycomb vaulting in the large reception halls and the intricate stalactite decoration of the arches.

After the Moors

After the Reconquest of Iberia in the 15th century, the Catholic kings lived in the Alhambra for a time, adding a palace of their own, but by the 18th century, it was abandoned, falling into disrepair. Among other things, it became a gypsy encampment, a military hospital, and a prison. It was rediscovered by the Romantics in the 19th century, who were enchanted by its decaying beauty. The importance of the site was eventually recognized, and it was declared a National Monument in 1870. It has since been accepted as a World Heritage Site (1984).

▽ COURT OF THE LIONS

Located in the heart of the harem section of the palace, this fountain with its 12 marble lions dates from the reign of Muhammad V (1338–1391).

